in itself a mark of respect. The PM was equally gracious and made me feel at ease right from the beginning. At dinner later, which Veena could unfortunately not attend, one of the things he mentioned was the importance of conserving resources, including electricity. He pointed out that even in his own office, only those lights were kept on which were absolutely essential and not all over. That immediately struck a chord with me since it was one of the things I had been insisting upon, without much success, from my time as Army Commander ARTRAC. I resolved then and there to persist with my efforts as, after all, I even had the endorsement of the PM himself.

Before we knew it, Army Day was upon us, including a press conference prior to Army Day itself, the Army Day Parade and the At Home, a reception hosted on the lawns of the Army House. The press conference is a gauntlet that has to be run, full of surprises and scope for either getting ambushed or making gaffes of your own. As my first 'presser', to be held in the Manekshaw Centre, it was quite stressful preparing for it. In a departure from the past, I decided to make a short opening statement, which I felt would set the tone not only for the presser but for my tenure and my vision of the future. I gave out seven key facets (ABC-IT-PQ) namely:

Allegiance. To the Constitution of India, to dispel the feeling that the Army was being politicized.

Belief. In ourselves, the organization and the country. Faith in superiors and subordinates alike.

Consolidation. To build upon our legacy and not to undertake change for the sake of change.

Integration. Both within the Army and between the Services.

Training. To cater for integration and enhance operational efficiency.

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